THE AD VERT

What makes a successful ad?

Photo by Oleg Yershov

The Ad That Changed Advertising

Why 'Got Milk?' is one of the Greatest Ad Campaigns of All Time

Paula Scher on Creating Brand Identities

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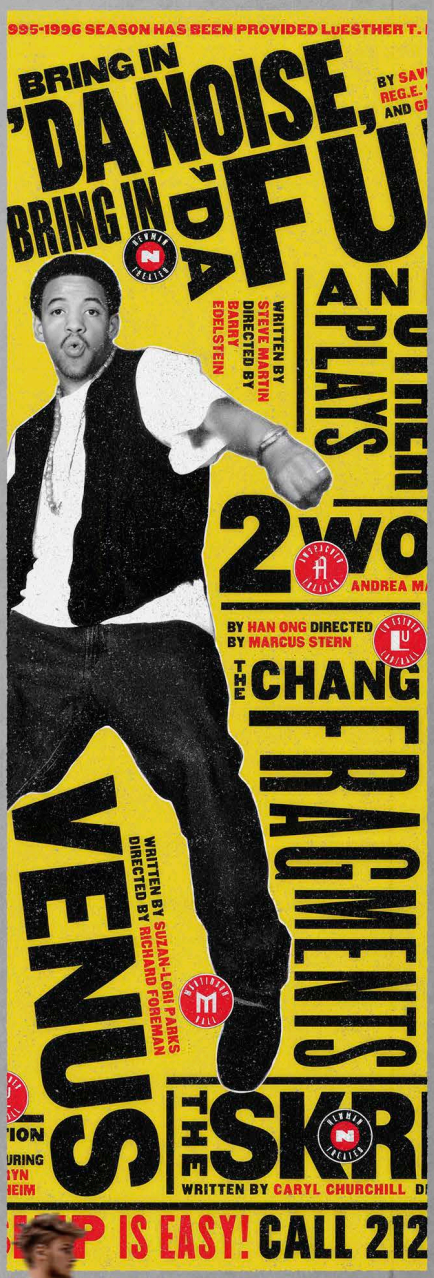
Got Milk? (1997)



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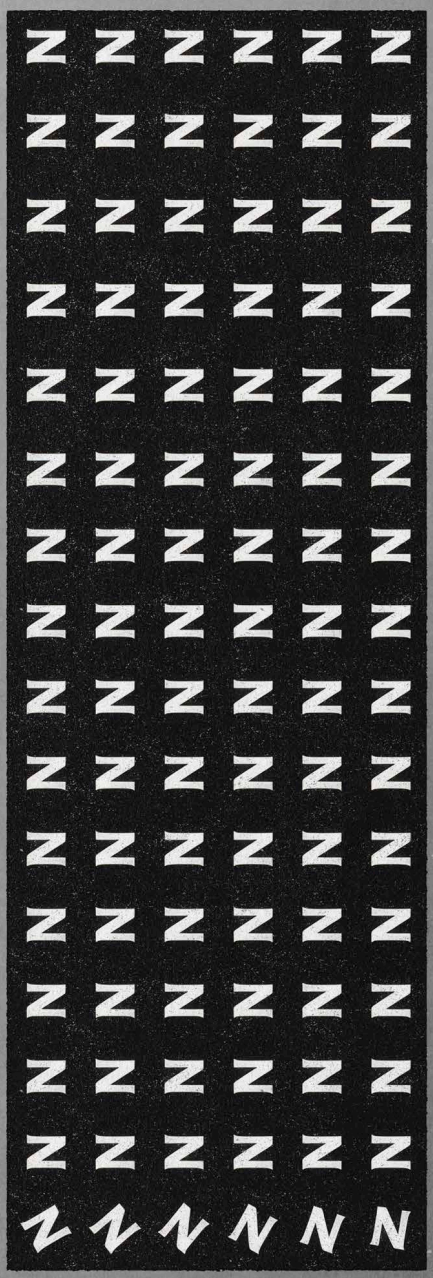

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The Ad That CHANGED *Advertising*

The Story Behind Volkswagen's *'Think Small'* Campaign

The Volkswagen was beginning to sell extensively throughout Europe during the 1950s as laws regulating exports from Germany were relaxed. The car was becoming popular. Through word of mouth advertising, the Volkswagen was even selling in America to those who weren't convinced by the stylish and expensive offerings from Chevrolet and Oldsmobile.

With sales of 100,000 Volkswagens in 1958, the major manufacturers could no longer ignore the market for small cars and were gearing up to release their own. To tackle this incoming threat Volkswagen sent a man named Carl Hahn to America. His job was to do something that Volkswagen hadn't done before— ***advertise.***

Photo by Oleg Yershov

"We didn't try to shout. We just told the truth"

-Bill Bernbach

Chrysler (1960)

Oldsmobile "Rockets You Out of the Ordinary" (1960)

Dodge Dart "Economy Cars" (1960)

Dodge Dart: 3 great series—Seneca, Pioneer, Phoenix—20 beautiful models, V-8 and "6"

Make way for the all-new

DODGE DART

line of economy cars in the low-price field!

he Dodge Dart has a *one-piece* This Unibody is stronger, comfortable, virtu- and rust. The other ad- "6"

engine, new Free-Flight Power, new Vacuum Door Locks,* Torsion-Aire Ride, push-button driving*—all at wonderfully low prices that mean you can own a Dart—right now!

*Optional at extra cost

ge Dart is priced model for ther low-price cars

CAR	CAR C
	Biscayne
	Air

u've found something great . . .

cketing new pace that makes 'or '60 is just the car to take

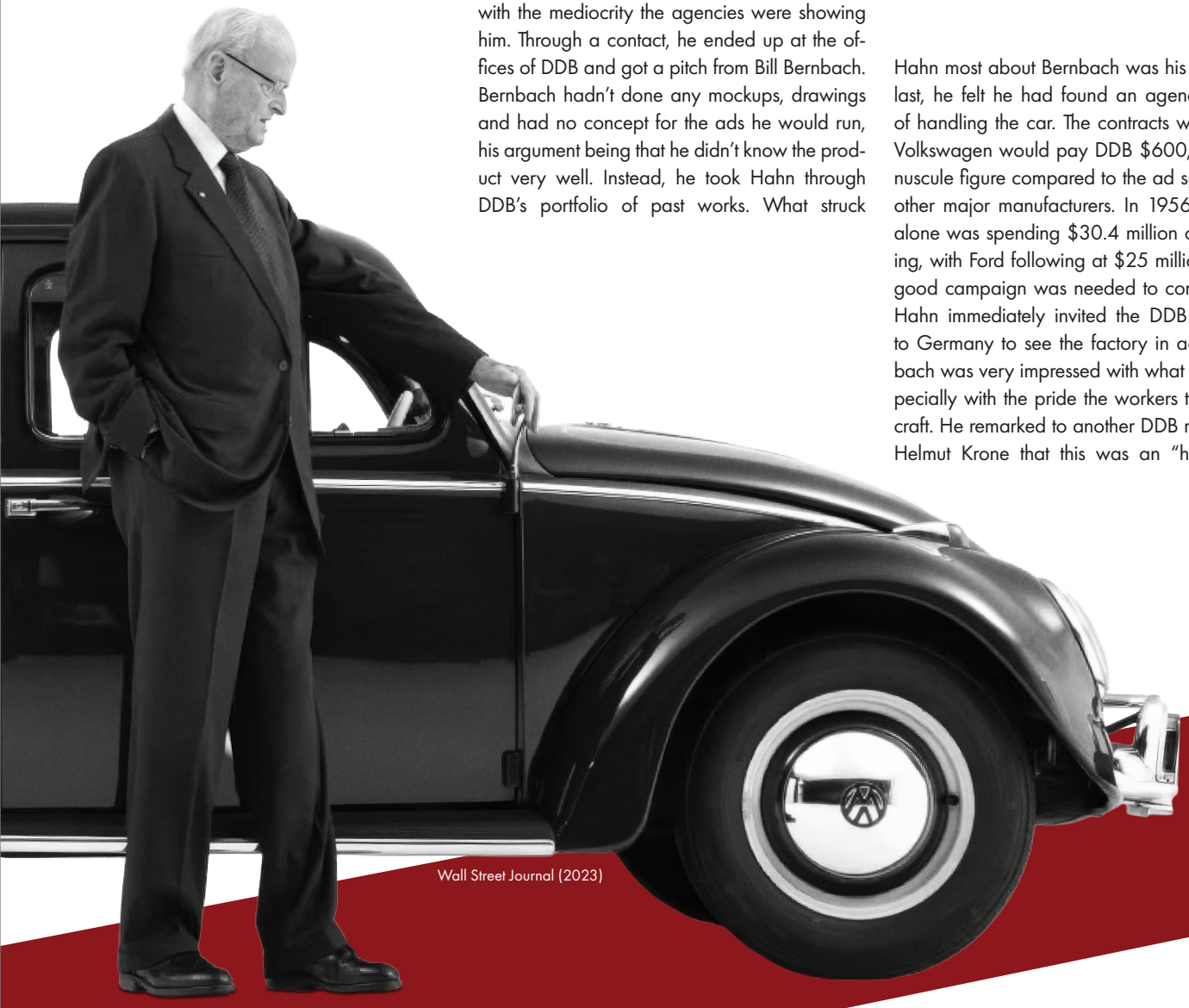
is series . . . the Dynamic ean performance, quality

cal authorized Quality

MOTORS CORPORATION

CHANGING PERCEPTIONS

Carl Hahn visited many agencies on Madison Avenue and was disappointed with most of what they were showing him. The majority of companies, eager to impress, had done plenty of spec work showing an illustration of the car on a beautiful driveway with a nice family standing admiringly around it. Hahn was less than impressed with the mediocrity the agencies were showing him. Through a contact, he ended up at the offices of DDB and got a pitch from Bill Bernbach. Bernbach hadn't done any mockups, drawings and had no concept for the ads he would run, his argument being that he didn't know the product very well. Instead, he took Hahn through DDB's portfolio of past works. What struck Hahn most about Bernbach was his honesty. At last, he felt he had found an agency capable of handling the car. The contracts were signed; Volkswagen would pay DDB $600,000, a minuscule figure compared to the ad spend of the other major manufacturers. In 1956, Chevrolet alone was spending $30.4 million on advertising, with Ford following at $25 million. A really good campaign was needed to compete. Carl Hahn immediately invited the DDB team over to Germany to see the factory in action. Bernbach was very impressed with what he saw, especially with the pride the workers took in their craft. He remarked to another DDB man named Helmut Krone that this was an "honest car".



Wall Street Journal (2023)

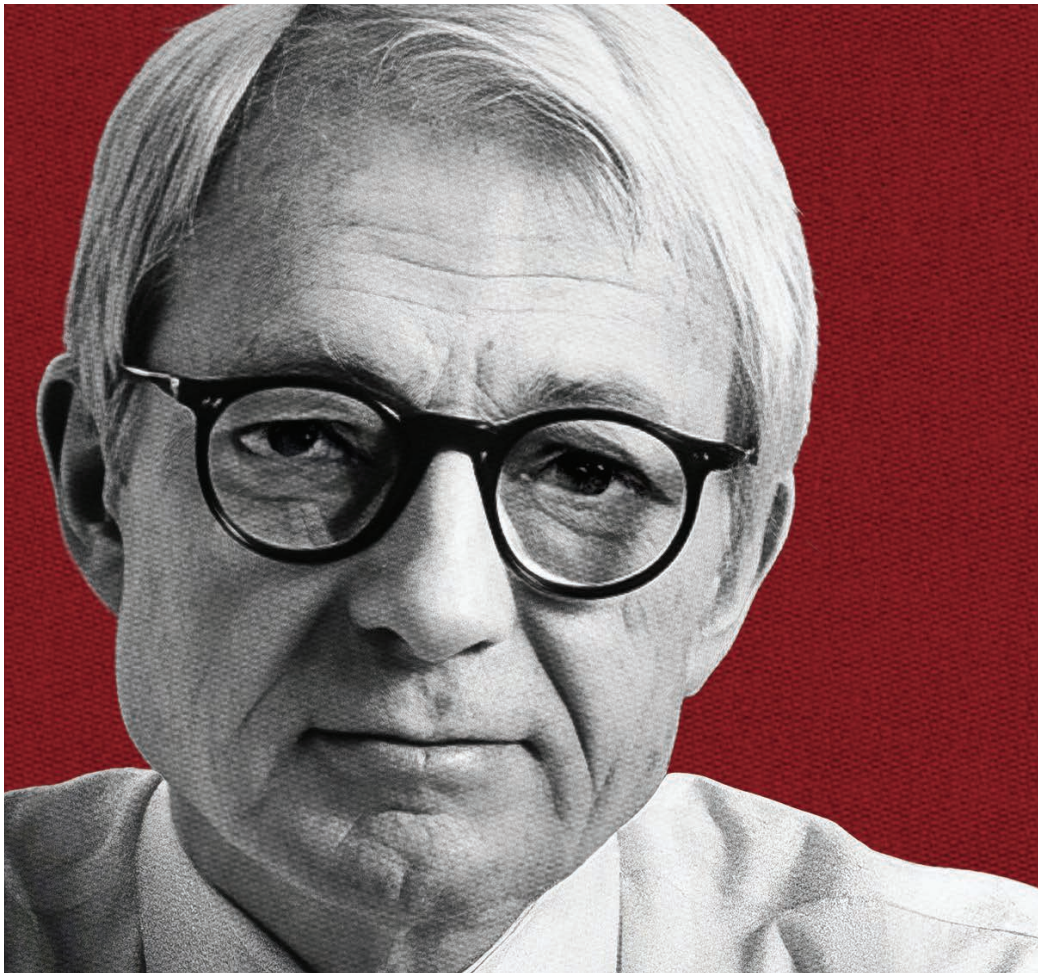


Photo by Arnold Newman

HELMUT KRONE

was born in New York in 1925, shortly after his parents had emigrated from Germany. As a young man, he was prompted to enter print advertising when he saw the work of Paul Rand. He later joined DDB as an art director. Krone was described by his colleagues as "a complex kraut" and "a fidgety perfectionist who worked with deadly Teutonic patience". The simple layouts he designed didn't betray the countless hours agonising over tiny details. DDB was actually already promoting the Volkswagen for a local car dealer. Krone was working on that campaign, so it was only natural that he was given the main account. He also personally owned a Volkswagen. Like all the teams at DDB, Krone (the art director) worked alongside a copywriter, in this case a Jewish man who wasn't bothered with the Nazi connections.

Julian Koenig was born in 1921, also in New York City. He had an on-off relationship with advertising, feeling frustrated at the lack of creativity he was permitted to express in his writing. After a brief stint as a professional horse better, he joined DDB as a copywriter in 1958. Working with Helmut Krone was apparently a challenge. Krone was unhappy with the honest approach Bernbach wanted to take. He initially wanted to present the car the way the other agencies had intended to — make the car as American as possible. Krone was also uncomfortable with the idea of selling"the Führer's car".

It was when the client, advertising manager Helmut Schmitz read Koenig's copy that he noticed a small line. The copy went "maybe we got so big because we thought small". Schmitz pointed at "think small" and said that was to be the headline. Koenig was pleased with this — his original headline had actually been "Think Small" but he'd been talked out of it by Krone who had wanted "Willkommen".

The art director was very unhappy with this development, and it took an intervention by Bernbach to persuade him to come up with some layouts. After much experimentation, Krone settled on a traditional ad layout, with an untraditional image. The headline and three column body was a traditional format used in a lot of advertising — Krone jokingly called it "The Olgivy Layout", Olgivy being an agency

Krone felt was creatively inferior. Part of the genius Krone possessed was the ability to take something familiar and alter it just enough to make it new.

This included setting the heading and body text in a sans-serif typeface, Futura. Most copy up until this time had been set in serif typefaces. Widows and orphans were everywhere. Krone actually cut them into the original ad with a razor blade — he was deliberately going for a halting and natural quality. He even instructed Koenig to write the copy in this way. The result of all these widows and orphans is an imperfection and honesty that couldn't be achieved with a more "professional" look. The quirky typesetting perfectly complemented the personality that Koenig gave his writing. A full stop was placed at the end of the headline, forcing the reader to stop and think about what they had just read. Putting a full stop after headlines would eventually become a trademark for Krone.

Then there's the Volkswagen logo, set awkwardly between the second and third columns. Krone hated using logos in his ads. Some of his other well known campaigns such as those for Avis didn't even have a logo. But by putting the Volkswagen logo where the reader didn't expect it meant this did not feel like a normal ad. Finally, there's the car. Krone settled on using a photo of the vehicle, not a fancy illustration like everyone else was doing. It is placed in the upper left corner, on a slight angle and in an ocean of white space.

The entire ad was printed in black and white, mainly because Volkswagen didn't have enough money to print it in colour. This created a very striking effect when it was viewed next to all the other colourful pages in Life Magazine, where it first appeared for consumers. Everything about the ad screams honesty and simplicity.

Krone hated the ad he'd put together. In fact, he hated it so much he deliberately left the country when it was first published. Expecting a hailstorm of criticism on his return, Krone found himself being praised for his work, although Koenig said it was only later that the Think Small ad became famous.

At the time, the advert was viewed with suspicion by those on Madison Avenue. The public, however, had a different reaction. People talked about it around the water cooler. Teenagers ripped it out of magazines and pinned it to their walls. It became, temporarily, more than just another ad. The sales figures backed up the approach when DDB learned about the sales impacts the ads were having.

Julian Koenig left DDB in 1959 to start his own agency and Helmut Krone was paired with another copywriter, Bob Levenson. Levenson rewrote the Think Small copy and the ad was released again in 1960 with a few artistic changes by Krone. Levenson understood that the new approach to the Volkswagen campaign required a new tone of voice, more than perhaps Koenig had. He understood that the copy had to look visually great as well as telling a compelling story in a self-deprecating and intelligent way.

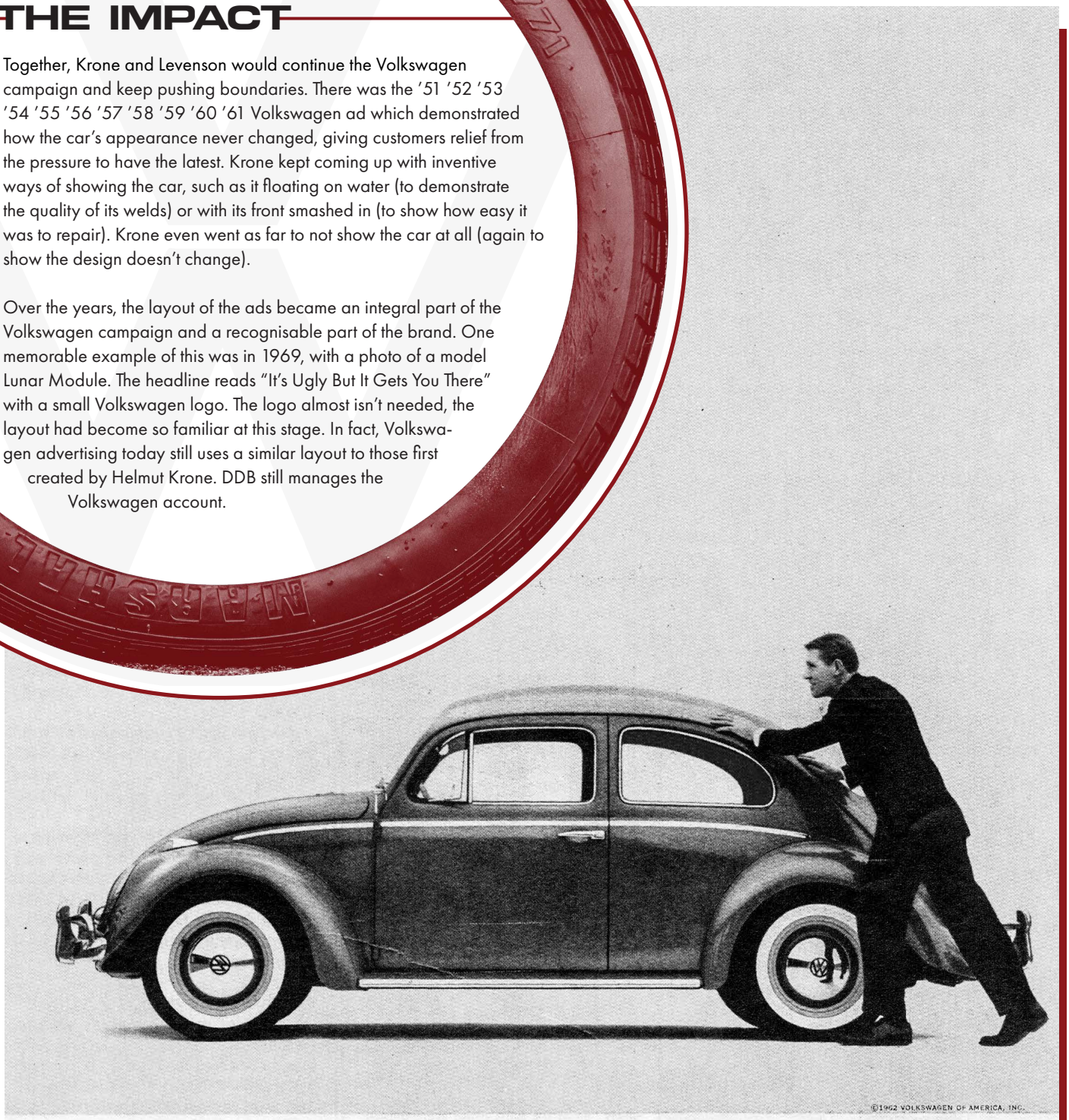
"A perfectionist is someone who finishes the backside of a drawer, which I consider completely unnecessary."

Helmut Krone

THE IMPACT

Together, Krone and Levenson would continue the Volkswagen campaign and keep pushing boundaries. There was the '51 '52 '53 '54 '55 '56 '57 '58 '59 '60 '61 Volkswagen ad which demonstrated how the car's appearance never changed, giving customers relief from the pressure to have the latest. Krone kept coming up with inventive ways of showing the car, such as it floating on water (to demonstrate the quality of its welds) or with its front smashed in (to show how easy it was to repair). Krone even went as far to not show the car at all (again to show the design doesn't change).

Over the years, the layout of the ads became an integral part of the Volkswagen campaign and a recognisable part of the brand. One memorable example of this was in 1969, with a photo of a model Lunar Module. The headline reads "It's Ugly But It Gets You There" with a small Volkswagen logo. The logo almost isn't needed, the layout had become so familiar at this stage. In fact, Volkswagen advertising today still uses a similar layout to those first created by Helmut Krone. DDB still manages the Volkswagen account.



©1962 VOLKSWAGEN OF AMERICA, INC.

And if you run out of gas, it's easy to push.

See?

We think of everything.

Getting a Volkswagen to the side of the road is a pushover.

It's a little surprising that VW owners don't run out of gas more often.

A figure like 32 miles to the gallon can make you a little hazy about when you last filled up.

And you spend so little time in gas stations, there are almost no reminders.

You'll probably never need oil between changes, for example.

You'll never need water or anti-freeze because the engine is air-cooled.

40,000 miles on a set of tires won't break any Volkswagen records.

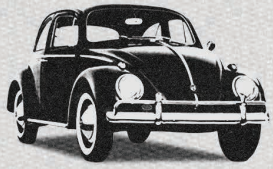
And repairs are few and far between.

So this year we've installed a gas gauge to help you remember.

But we haven't taken all the fun away.

You still have to remember to look at it.

As part of a cultural shift, the Think Small ad and the ones that followed marked a true shift in the advertising landscape. The customer was trusted to be smart enough to work things out since the copy didn't speak down to anyone. Suddenly there was an ad that appealed to people's intelligence in a way that the style based campaigns of the past had not. Honesty as a selling point had never really been tried before, at least on a major campaign such as for a large car manufacturer.



The ad tapped into a sense of disconnect that the public was feeling as a result of being pressured to buy and consume for so many years. This was especially felt by younger people. Those born after the Second World War saw their parents encouraged to buy and consume their way to happiness and they rejected this (to a large degree). The Think Small campaign was created just as this voice was starting to make its presence heard — it would be heard loudly throughout the sixties. The Volkswagen Beetle became an integral part of the counter culture in America, helped in large part by the highly effective advertising DDB kept producing.

©1960 Volkswagen. Remastered 2026 by Oleg Yershov.

Think small.

Our little car isn't so much of a novelty anymore.

A couple of dozen college kids don't try to squeeze inside it.

The guy at the gas station doesn't ask where the gas goes.

Nobody even stares at our shape.

In fact, some people who drive our little flivver don't even think 32 miles to the gallon is going any great guns.

Or using five pints of oil instead of five quarts.

Or never needing anti-freeze.

Or rocking up 40,000 miles on a set of tires.

That's because once you get used to some of our economies, you don't even think about them any more.

Except when you squeeze into a small parking spot. Or renew your small insurance. Or pay a small repair bill. Or trade in your old VW for a new one.

Think it over.

A PHOTOGRAPHIC RECONSTRUCTION

This spread features two recreations of the *Think Small* campaign, featuring a1:24 scale die-cast Volkswagen model captured in-studio. All photography, design, & writing was done by Oleg Yershov.

Inspired by *Think Small*. ©2026 by Oleg Yershov.

Oops.

Another scratch. But that's okay; accidents happen. In this world, cars get launched off stairs, banged into walls, and a rollover is just the end of a good race. And this shouldn't change with time.

Just like toys on a shelf, new cars are made bigger, brighter, and more complex, making older versions obsolete.

The Beetle was built with a radical idea: if it isn't there, it can't break. And if it does break, it's easily fixed–a part from ten years ago still fits today. Its parts were designed to be modular, simple, and above all, replaceable. It's not just a piece of engineering; it's a friend you know you can trust with your life.

A car shouldn't just be a purchase; it should be a partnership. In a world of fleeting trends and obsolescence, the Beetle remains a constant—an honest machine for an unpredictable world.

It's not just about getting there; it's about the peace of mind in knowing you always will.

Inspired by *Think Small*. ©2026 by Oleg Yershov.

A familiar feeling.

Our little car starts earlier than most. Before permits. Before needing to run errands. Before anyone tells you what driving is supposed to feel like.

It doesn't go very fast and gets banged into walls. Its paint gets chipped, its wheels start to wobble, and it doesn't even stay upright most of the time.

It gets launched off the stairs and left behind in the grass. It survives backyard mud pits and gets lost between cushions. Its stickers peel and windows crack.

At some point, it gets forgotten and sealed in a box, locked away in the shadows of a basement.

But the bond never breaks.

Because when you spot rows of unfamiliar steel, there will be one car that evokes a connection. Recognizable from the other end of the lot, its silhouette is timeless. When the key turns, it feels like you've known each other for years. And you have. **Some cars you grow into. Ours you grow up with.**

ADVERTISING & PSYCH

Advertising is a process of persuading an audience to buy products, contract services, or support a candidate or issue. Advertising creates a reality for the consumer—both the image of the product, company, or candidate and the need for a product or service.

OLOGY

Advertisements try to change consumer attitudes toward a product, company, or candidate. Attitudes consist of three components: belief, affect (emotion), and intention to act. The ultimate goal of the advertiser is to persuade the consumer to act— ***to buy the product, support the candidate or company,***

INTRODUCTION

Advertising is one form of mass communication. A classified ad from around 1000 BCE offered a reward (a gold coin) to anyone finding and returning a runaway slave. Johannes Gutenberg, an inventor and metallurgist, introduced movable-type printing to Europe in the fifteenth century, which allowed for the printed mass communication of advertising. The Industrial Revolution of the nineteenth century cultivated commercialism and transportation of national publications, including a large number of magazines. Advertising proliferated on the radio after 1920, on television after 1945, and on the Internet starting in the mid-1990s.

Psychologists study advertising as a form of communication in the context of cognition and psycholinguistics. Consumers "read" advertisements, whether in print, on television, or online, similarly to the way they read books. Therefore, one way to examine how consumers understand and react to advertisements is by researching comprehension of narrative scripts. For advertisements to effectively change consumer attitudes, their message must be understood. Psychologists study how consumers process the information in advertisements. Sometimes information processing leads to miscomprehension, which, often unintentionally, can create in the consumer false ideas about the product.

From a more social-cognitive and humanistic perspective, psychologists look at the appeals advertisers make to human needs. Advertisements associate basic needs and natural responses to those needs with their products. Advertisers classically condition consumers to respond to their products as they would to any stimulus naturally satisfying a need. Sometimes these associations are not consciously made.

NARRATIVE SCRIPT

The first step in changing consumer attitudes toward an advertised product is to persuade the consumer that the informational content of the advertisement is true. One way advertisers create belief in the consumer is by following a narrative script, a simple plot such as a child might hear when a parent reads a story.

The narrative script is a knowledge structure composed of exposition, complication, and resolution. The exposition introduces the characters and settings of the story, the complication is a developing problem, and the resolution is the solution to the problem. Many advertisements take the form of the narrative script to facilitate comprehension and belief. For example, John, Jane, and their daughter Judy are playing at the park (exposition). While swinging, Judy falls on the ground, scraping her knee (complication). Jane soothes Judy and dresses her wound by applying a plastic bandage coated with an antibacterial agent (resolution). The consumer is comfortable with the narrative script as an understandable and entertaining format. The advertiser is able to hold the audience's attention. The resolution is associated with the product (bandages).

INFORMATION PROCESSING

The consumer's belief in the advertisement is affected by how the consumer processes the information presented in it. There are eight stages of information processing involved in the comprehension of advertisements. The belief component of the consumer's attitude toward the product can be formed or modified at any stage. The first stage is exposure: the consumer must have the opportunity to perceive the advertisement. The second stage is attention: the consumer may pay attention to part or all of an advertisement. The third stage is comprehension: the consumer must understand the information in the ad. The fourth stage is evaluation: the consumer assesses the information presented in the ad. The fifth stage is encoding: the consumer encodes, or saves, the advertised information in long-term memory. Later, the sixth stage, retrieval, in which the consumer retrieves the encoded information, can occur. The seventh stage is decision: the consumer decides to buy (or not buy) the advertised product.

MISCOMPREHENSION

The final stage is the action of buying the product. Advertisers may persuade consumers to buy their product by intentionally inducing miscomprehension. The basis of the miscomprehension is the tendency for people to encode inferences, or interpretations, of stated advertising claims. Therefore, the consumer later remembers inferences made, but not explicitly stated, about a product. At no point is the advertiser presenting false information, but the advertisement is structured in a way that induces the consumer to draw a specific inference. An advertisement might use hedge words such as "may" or "could." For example, pain reliever Brand A "may help" prevent heart attacks.

Other advertisements contain elliptical comparatives. In an elliptical comparison, the standard that something is being compared to is intentionally left out. The consumer naturally completes the comparison with the most logical standard. However, the true standard might not be the most logical. For example, cereal Brand A "gives you more." More what? A logical standard might be "more vitamins." The true standard might be "more heartburn." An advertisement might imply causation when in actuality the relationship is correlational. Juxtaposing two imperative statements implies that the first statement leads to, or causes, the next statement: Buy Brand A tires. Drive safely.

PSYCHOLOGICAL APPEALS

Advertisers use psychological appeals directed to basic human needs. Abraham Maslow, the American humanist psychologist who developed a hierarchy of needs in the 1960s, theorized that all humans have needs that must be met to achieve self-fulfillment. The most basic are the physiological needs, such as food, water, and shelter. People also need basic feelings: feelings of security, belonging, and being loved, as well as feelings of self-esteem. The final need is self-actualization, the highest form of self-fulfillment. Advertisements may focus on any one or a combination of these needs.

Psychological appeals in advertising influence the emotional component of people's attitudes. The advertised product is associated with positive emotions such as fun, love, belonging, warmth, excitement, and satisfaction. Advertisements can also be based on fear, as when advertisers try to convince consumers that there will be negative consequences if they do not buy their product, focusing on the need for safety. For example, buying any tire other than the one advertised will increase the risk of an automobile accident. Advertisements also appeal to the human need for self-esteem, which is heightened through power and success. An ad may aim to associate the product with the consumer being the best or having the most.

CLASSIC CONDITIONING

Russian physiologist Ivan Petrovich Pavlov discovered the process of classical, or Pavlovian, conditioning in the early twentieth century. An unconditioned stimulus (US) naturally produces an unconditioned response (UR). For example, the image of a baby may naturally produce pleasant, even maternal or paternal, feelings. In classical conditioning, the unconditioned stimulus is paired with a neutral stimulus (NS), one that does not normally produce the unconditioned response. For example, a can of soda (NS) can be paired with a picture of a baby (US). With several pairings, the neutral stimulus will become the conditioned stimulus (CS), eliciting the unconditioned response without the actual association with the unconditioned stimulus. Once conditioning occurs, the unconditioned response becomes the conditioned response (CR). Thus, the can of soda becomes the conditioned stimulus when it alone produces pleasant feelings (CR).

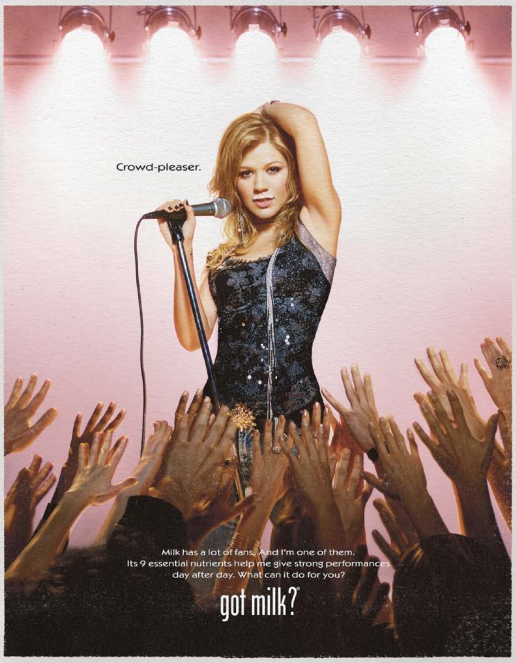
SUBLIMINAL ADVERTISING

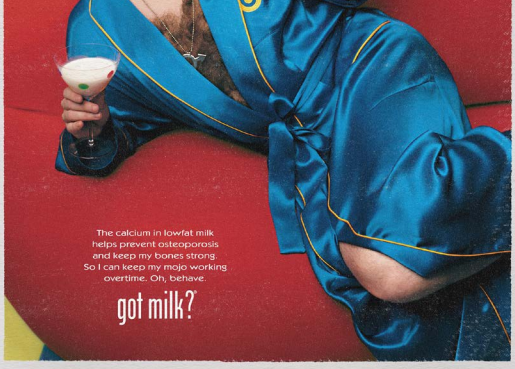
Advertisers use classical conditioning to associate a product with a stimulus that elicits the desired responses—belief in the product, positive emotions about the product, intent to buy the product—in the consumer. While shopping, a consumer sees the advertised can of soda, associates it with positive feelings, and therefore is more likely to purchase this brand of soda.

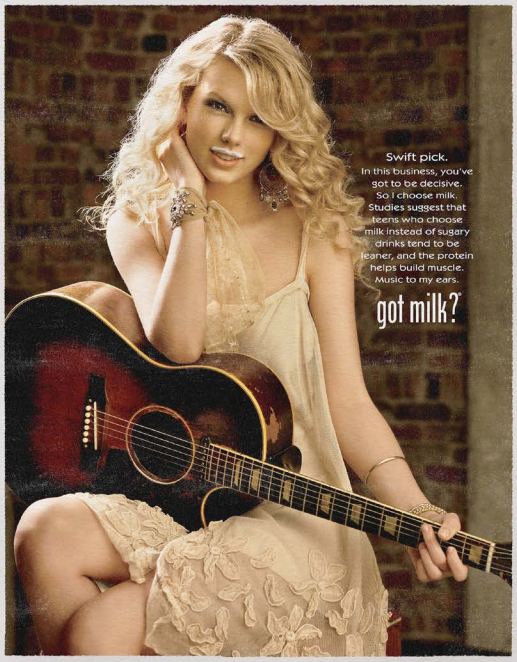
Stimuli that are subliminal are below the threshold of conscious perception. Consumers are not normally aware of subliminal stimuli unless they consciously look for them. For example, an image on a product package may contain the shape of sexual organs. There is some weak evidence that subliminal messages in advertising may positively affect the emotional quality of consumer attitudes toward a product. However, there is no evidence that subliminal messages affect consumer behavior toward a product.

THINKING VS FEELING

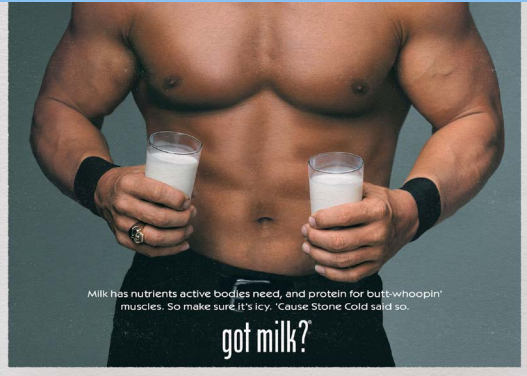
According to the University of Southern California (USC)'s Master of Science in Applied Psychology, advertising campaigns that perform well are almost twice as likely to employ emotional content (31 percent) as rational content (16 percent). An emotional response is more effective in inducing a person to complete a transaction, such as a purchase, than the content itself. One of the most powerful of these responses is when an advertisement comes off as "likeable." USC suggests audiences have two type of emotive, or emotional, responses: empathetic or creative. An empathetic response is when a person empathizes with a brand after being exposed to an advertisement. A creative response prompts the audience to feel that the product is imaginative and "cutting-edge." To achieve and maintain engagement, advertisers will try to have an audience feel joy or surprise immediately and to experience emotional ups and downs in the course of its advertisement.

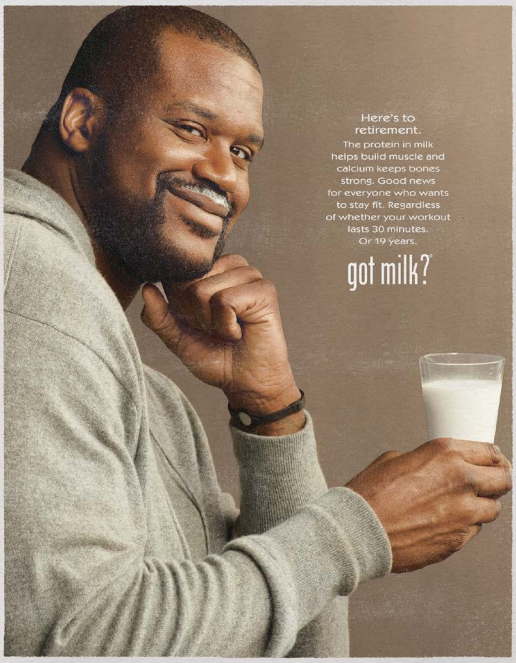




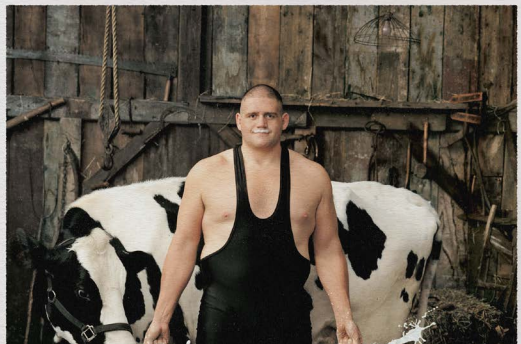


GotMilk (1995 - 2010)

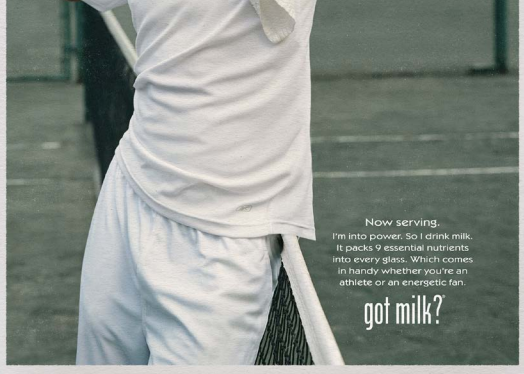




why got milk?® is one of the greatest ad campaigns of all time



If you grew up in America between the 1950s and 1990s, you probably took for granted that milk was good for you. You may have drunk it with every meal: A bowl of cereal for breakfast. A half-pint carton on the cafeteria tray at lunch. A tall glass of milk to wash down dinner. By the early '90s, however, "good for you" was apparently not good enough. The USDA and the dairy industry were ringing the alarm bells: Milk consumption was declining, putting a billion-dollar industry at risk. So a clutch of new marketing groups, created by the government and funded by a flood of cash, took a new tack: advertising. Marketing groups with names like California Milk Processor Board and MilkPEP hired ad agencies to fill America's TV screens, magazines, and toys with advertisements for milk. Enter "Got Milk?" their most famous ad campaign, which set out to do something as elusive as it was ambitious—to make milk cool.

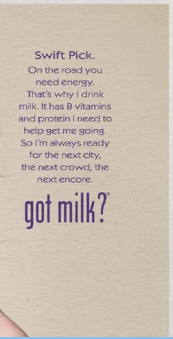


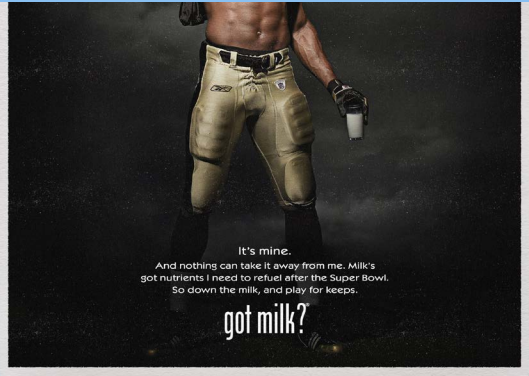
The USDA Dietary Guidelines for Americans recommends two to three servings of dairy per day, and it's been that way for decades. But little do most people know, drinking fresh milk is a thoroughly modern phenomenon.

It wasn't until refrigeration and pasteurization brought fresh milk to the masses in the early 20th century that Americans drink milk without worrying about getting sick. Farmers began producing so much, in fact, that after World War II, there was a nationwide surplus. So the federal government got involved. It bought up excess milk, which wound up in government cheese and on cafeteria trays via the national school lunch program, created in 1946.

Fast-forward to the 1980s, to the Reagan era, and a free-market ideology had taken hold. There was little appetite for agricultural subsidies. Legislators began favoring a model they'd rolled out in the '30s with Florida citrus growers: taxing farmers to fund advertising campaigns.

GotMilk (1995 - 2010)





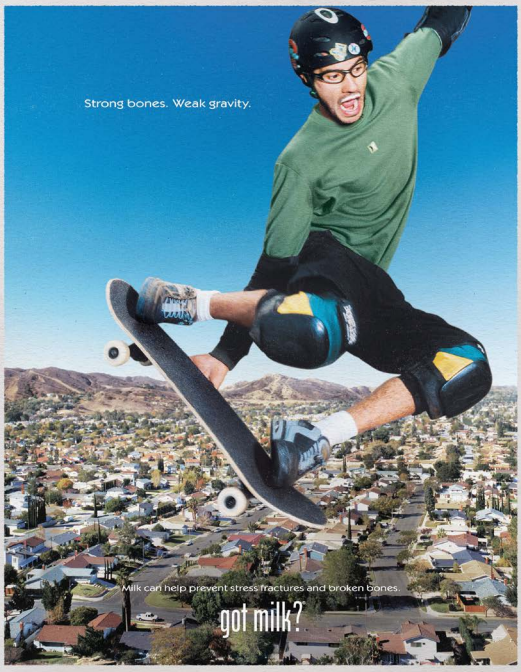
These "agricultural commodity checkoff programs," as they came to be called, were rooted in the idea that the government shouldn't solve surpluses by having farmers produce less. Instead, farmers could help fund efforts to convince consumers to buy more of their products. In her 2016 history "The Incredible, Edible Checkoff," Sarah Milov, history professor at University of Virginia, described this shift in thinking as "the national stomach, rather than the national purse, [underwriting] American agriculture."

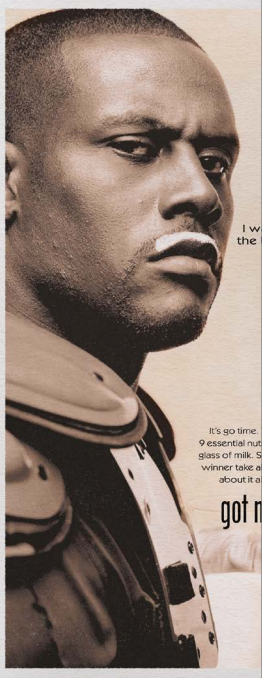
Checkoff programs became the new normal. In the '80s and early '90s they exploded, resulting in a flood of food advertisements that anyone who tuned in at the time will recognize: "The Incredible, Edible Egg," "Pork: The Other White Meat," and "Beef: It's What's for Dinner," to name a few.

The dairy industry didn't get one checkoff program—it got many, a near-impenetrable morass of organizations with generic-sounding names (case in point: Dairy Management Inc.). The boom started with the federal Dairy Production Stabilization Act of 1983, which required farmers to pay 15 cents for every 100 pounds of milk (11.6 gallons) they produced to fund research, product development, and advertising. Then came MilkPEP (funded by a checkoff for milk buyers) and the California state equivalent, the California Milk Processor Board, established in 1993.

In the early '90s, California's milk industry was sweating about the future. Nationally, milk consumption had declined almost 20 percent over the previous two decades, down to less than one cup per person per day.

Hoping to curb the crisis, the California Milk Processor Board hired an ad exec named Jeff Manning, whom they tasked with rebranding the beverage. But the problem, as Manning writes in Got Milk? The Book, wasn't the public perception of milk—90





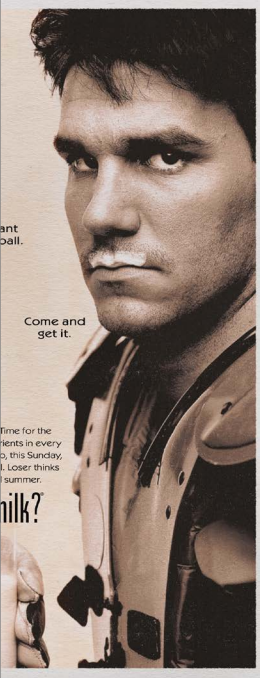
percent of Americans thought milk was healthy—but rather two other factors: Americans were dining out more, skipping the home-cooked meals that would've been accompanied by milk or juice. Many Americans also thought of milk as a kid's beverage, and in the post-Baby Boom years, the percentage of the U.S. population under age 18 was shrinking.

More critically, though, soft drinks, bottled iced tea, and bottled water were crowding out milk cartons in supermarket cases—the result of extremely well-funded branding and advertising. Soda consumption in America was crescendoing toward its 1998 peak, the year when Americans drank 53 gallons per person. "Milk was being outpackaged, outspent, and outflanked," Manning wrote. Americans had "shifted gears and left it behind."

That was the panorama when the board handed Manning a whopping $25 million ($51.3 million in today's dollars) to create its first ad campaign. Manning teamed up with Goodby, Silverstein & Partners, an agency whose idea it was to skip the "good for you" talk and remind consumers that they loved milk so much, they'd panic if it ever went missing.

The earliest Got Milk? TV spots were unlike any government-sponsored ads America had ever seen. In one bizarre sketch, an Alexander Hamilton buff receives a surprise call offering him $10,000 to name Hamilton's assassin—problem was, he was eating a peanut butter sandwich and had run out of milk to clear his throat. (A young Michael Bay, who went on to make blockbusters like Bad Boys and Transformers, directed the spot.) Then there was the dad who ran out of milk at breakfast time and had to decide whether the baby or the cat should sacrifice their meal. The ads were witty, weird, and occasionally downright wicked. And they were such

GotMilk (1995 - 2010)

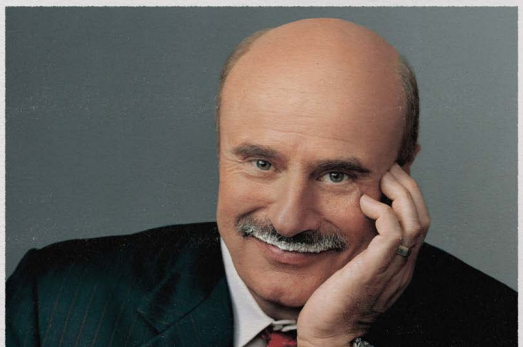


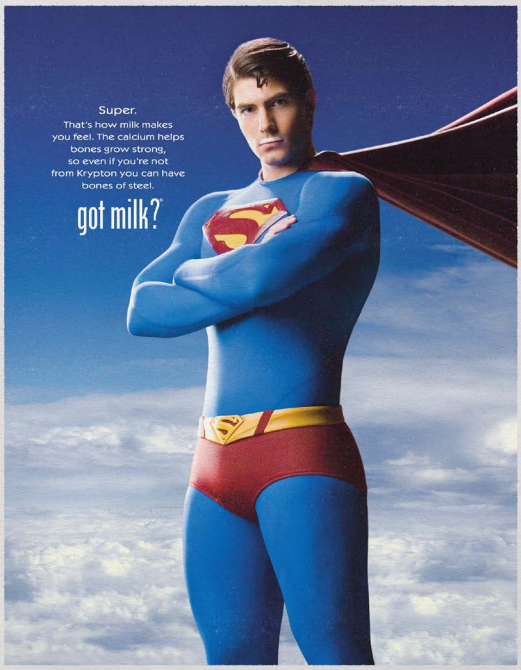
a runaway success that the national dairy checkoff organization took a page from California and licensed the campaign to run nationwide.

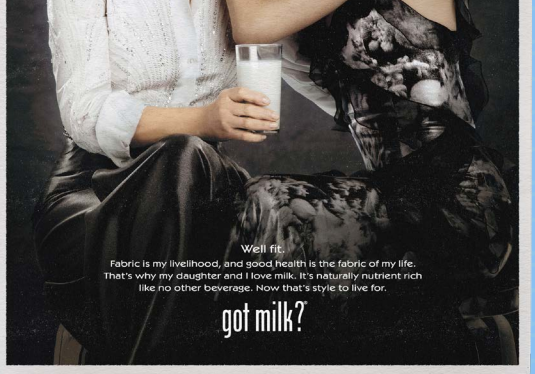
Around that time, MilkPEP, the national milk processor checkoff, joined the battle to make milk cool. Their contribution? Print ads featuring celebrities wearing milk mustaches. "You could not open a People magazine, or a Parade, without seeing a milk mustache," said Kikke Riedel of MilkPEP, who noted that the two campaigns joined forces in 1997 by tagging the photos with "Got Milk?" The ads, photographed by Annie Leibovitz, didn't just harness celebrity worship; they curated it, picking stars at the peak of their popularity such as a smizing Tyra Banks, Buffy's Sarah Michelle Gellar, the band Hanson, and athletes like New York Knicks player Patrick Ewing.

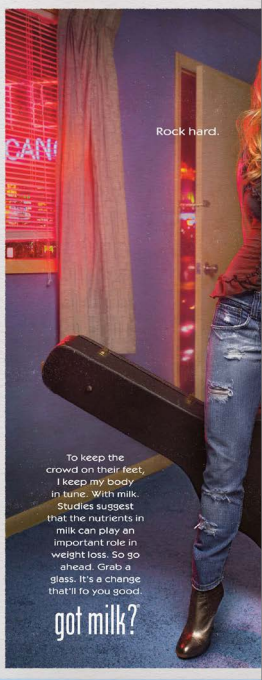
In Got Milk's heyday, the World Wide Web was in its infancy. Social media hadn't been dreamed up. So for A-listers, publicity opportunities like milk mustache ads—which were eye-popping headshots, distributed in national magazines—were golden. "We paid them very little money," Riedel said of the stars. "They would call us and beg to be in the campaign." TV gossip shows like Entertainment Tonight sometimes swooped in to film the photo shoot, doubling everyone's exposure. (An aside: Riedel now feels comfortable sharing that the mustaches were made with a "proprietary mix" of milk, ice cream, and sour cream.)

At the turn of the millennium, milk ads were ubiquitous. "Got Milk?" was printed on boxes of Cheerios and Oreos. Mattel produced a Got Milk? Hot Wheels toy truck, and toy stores stocked Got Milk? Barbies dressed in Holstein-patterned overalls.









By 1997, wrote Manning, "National awareness of 'Got Milk?' would be over 80 percent and pushing 90 percent among teens."

Dairy farmers loved the campaign. "I thought it was incredible," says Alan Mann, a lifelong dairy farmer from Oregon who sells his milk to the Darigold cooperative. "It was the first thing I knew of that went viral."

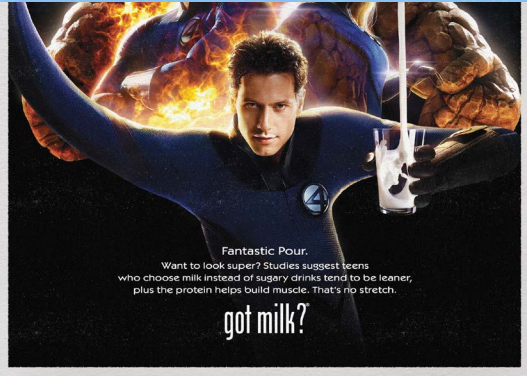
Whether Got Milk? was an early-days meme or a good old-fashioned cliché, it was effective. Copycat phrases popped up everywhere. Got beer? Got hair? Got marketing? Got Jesus? The California board didn't bother suing most imitators: Mann, for his part, loved spotting these copycats, because he knew they were basically free advertising.

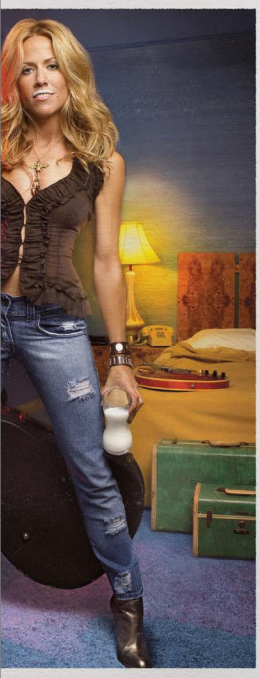
Milk did seem cool for a spell, but whether it got Americans to drink more milk is questionable. On the one hand, for a year or two in the mid-1990s, there was a microbump in milk drinking, as described in a corroborated 1999 study showing that milk checkoff ads caused a 6 percent hike in milk sales.

But by the end of the decade, the writing was on the wall: Americans were drinking less milk than ever, then averaging around two thirds of a cup per day per person. (By 2019, the last year with available statistics, that number would be less than a half a cup.) MilkPEP pulled the plug on the Got Milk? mustache campaign in 2014. It was the end of an era; The New Yorker wrote a eulogy.

Got Milk? could have only succeeded in the '90s. The ad campaign was forged in the crucible of the free-market optimism of the previous decade, propelled by network TV and glossy magazines at the peak of their popularity, and tinged with the wicked humor Gen X loved. Yet a single ad campaign,

GotMilk (1995 - 2010)





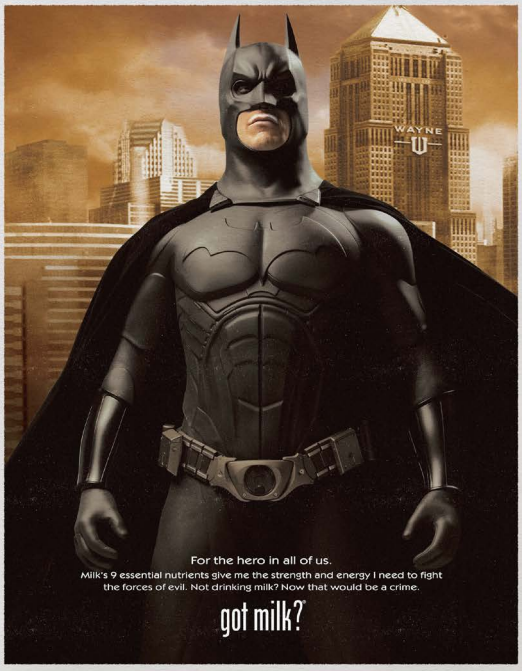
however savvy, couldn't compete against broader shifts in Americans' food and drink preferences. To be fair, Americans are still drinking plenty of milk—some 383 million gallons last July alone—But sales of bottled water, energy drinks, plant-based milks, and even kombucha are on the rise. In addition, we're eating out more and more. Concern over dairy cows' role in the climate crisis is growing. And as demographics shift, an ever larger percentage of Americans has trouble digesting lactose.

These days, instead of drinking milk, we're increasingly eating it—in the form of yogurt and cheese. Our cheese consumption has doubled since the early 1980s, and it's no coincidence: The dairy checkoffs that once poured big bucks into Got Milk? advertising have since reinvested in other dairy products.

As the New York Times reported, Dairy Management Inc., the national dairy checkoff program, paid Domino's Pizza to put 40% more cheese on its pies in 2010. A few years later, it partnered with Pizza Hut to create—and sell us on—stuffed-crust pizza. The move is arguably more controversial than the Got Milk? campaign, since it revolves around the USDA—the same government body that gave us dietary guidelines—promoting what is essentially fast food.

Looking back, Got Milk? seems almost noble in its "successful" failure. Compared to a slice of stuffed-crust pizza or a sugar-bomb energy drink, a good old-fashioned glass of milk seems like a pretty healthy choice.

got milk?®



PAULA Scher

on Creating Brand Identities

Paula Scher photographed by Madere (2010).

for NEW YORK'S Cultural Institutions

Where do you find your inspiration and what is your process when beginning a project?

There are a couple different ways to start, but I have inspiration stockpiled. I have a lifetime of absorbing artwork, other graphic design, history, movies, walking down the street—everything is fodder. The fodder's over here at one side of the brain, and on the other side are the people in the brief, and you're really looking and listening to your clients based on where they've been and where they're going, and then you begin to try to create a language and a basis for them to get where they're going, and that has to do with who they think their audience is, what their problems have been in the past, and how much they want to make a statement about who they are to be recognized and then lead them to how to do that, and it's a little bit of trial and error.

It's sort of like being in a lab. We make a series of experiments that are called phase one, and that's taking the input they gave us and making some demonstration that demonstrates type faces, color palettes, ideas, themes and motifs, and ways of seeing if a bunch of things are recognizable as one thing. It's a little bit like a scientific experiment. How much do you recognize this thing over here? Three are in a row, one looks weird. Okay, what's wrong with that? We have to figure that out and fix it. Or they all look alike, but if they look too much alike and they want to differentiate the plays, then you resolve those issues in phase two, so you can make corrections and accommodations.

Paula Scher - Bring in 'da Noise / Bring in 'da Funk

Then, in the third phase, you're teaching them how to work with it and figuring out how they're going execute it. That's the hardest phase of all, because sometimes I set up in-house art departments, so I'll find other people to do some of this work for us. Mostly we do the first launch and then we try to staff it, and that person would probably work with us pretty closely in the first six months to a year until they can really take it over.

Q&A

When you started working on rebranding The Public, what was your process for conceiving it, and how did you balance what the institution wanted to be with where it was in its history at that moment?

It was a radical departure. George Wolfe did not directly follow Joe Papp. There was JoAnne Akalaitis in between and she had continued some of what Papp's approach was to advertising. George wanted to make a complete departure to develop his own view of what the theatre should be, otherwise he would always look like a weaker version of Papp. So, the notion was to make it visible in New York City, to be inclusive of everyone, to be loud and proud and take the city by storm, and that's what we did.

It was typographic. The style of the posters in the first couple of seasons were pretty powerful. They were designed from the plays as much as the identities, so there was a real crossover. I don't do that anymore. Now, we do a season and the plays all have a look for the season, even if it's Hamilton. In the beginning we used to really design for each individual play very specifically and in those days they actually printed the posters and they bought newspaper advertisement where you could see the image, so it was more like a Broadway theatre.

That wasn't really effective for The Public, and now I advise the theatre groups against it because what happens is if one play's a hit, you remember the play, but you don't remember the theatre. If the play isn't a hit, you don't remember the play or the theatre. You just know that one image you saw and you don't know where it's from, and that's really bad for these group theatres. People don't have enough money collectively to really support one individual play. If it gets a lot of press, it'll be supported by itself. It's a tricky thing. But when you do a season, it's actually very visible because you're seeing it continually, so you recognize the place.

Paula Scher - Bring in 'da Noise / Bring in 'da Funk

ALL
STAR
ADS
Visuals That Set the Standard

Top: Braun *Middle:* Rimowa *Bottom:* Coca Cola

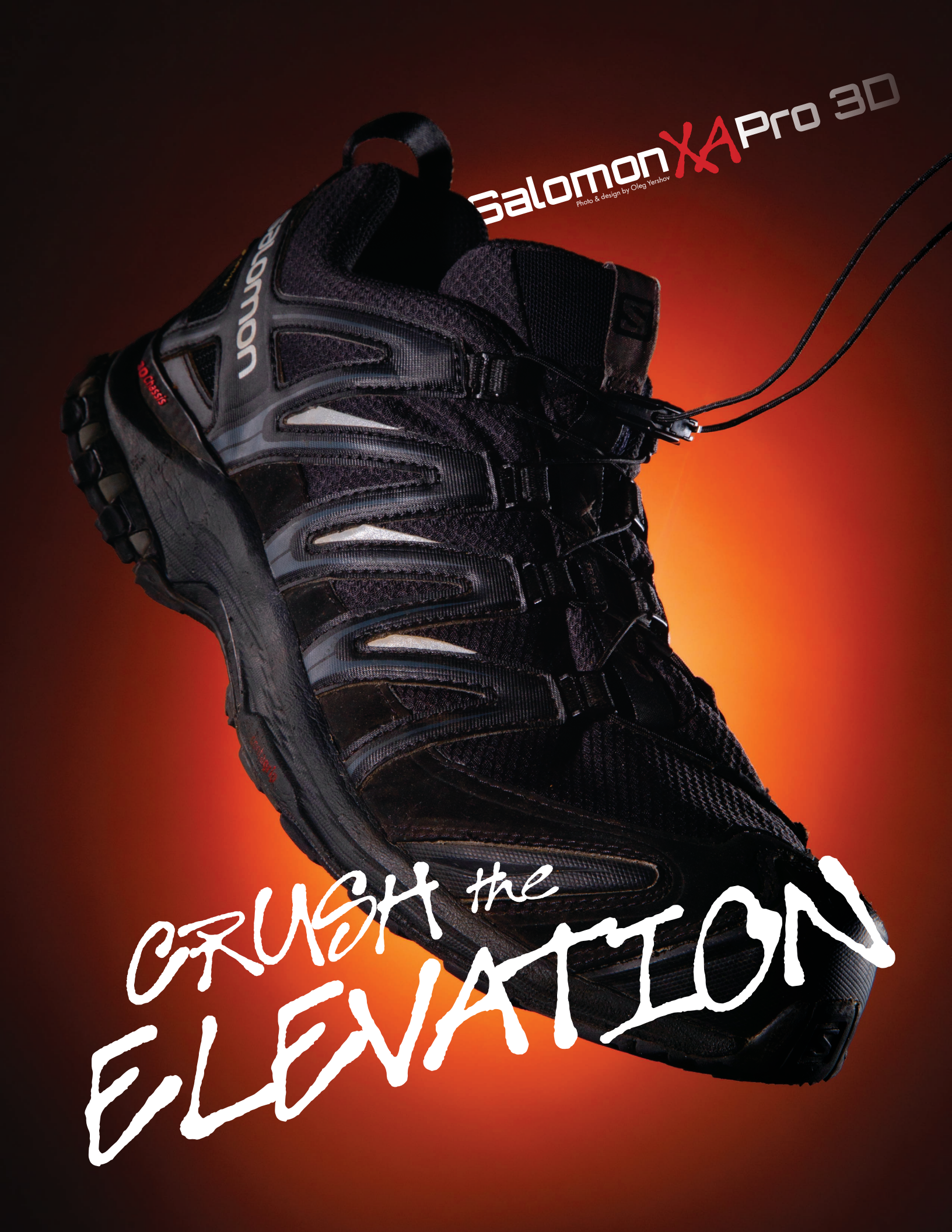
Mobile Ordering is here

IDEA

Nothing wakes you up as Nescafé

Top left: McDonalds *Top right:* Nike *Bottom left:* Ikea *Bottom right:* Nescafe

Top: Pepsi *Middle:* Doordash *Bottom:* Mitsubishi


Salomon XA Pro 3D
Photo & design by Oleg Yershov
CRUSH the
ELEVATION